

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 4 (Teaching Week 3): The state II — why can some states actually *do* things?

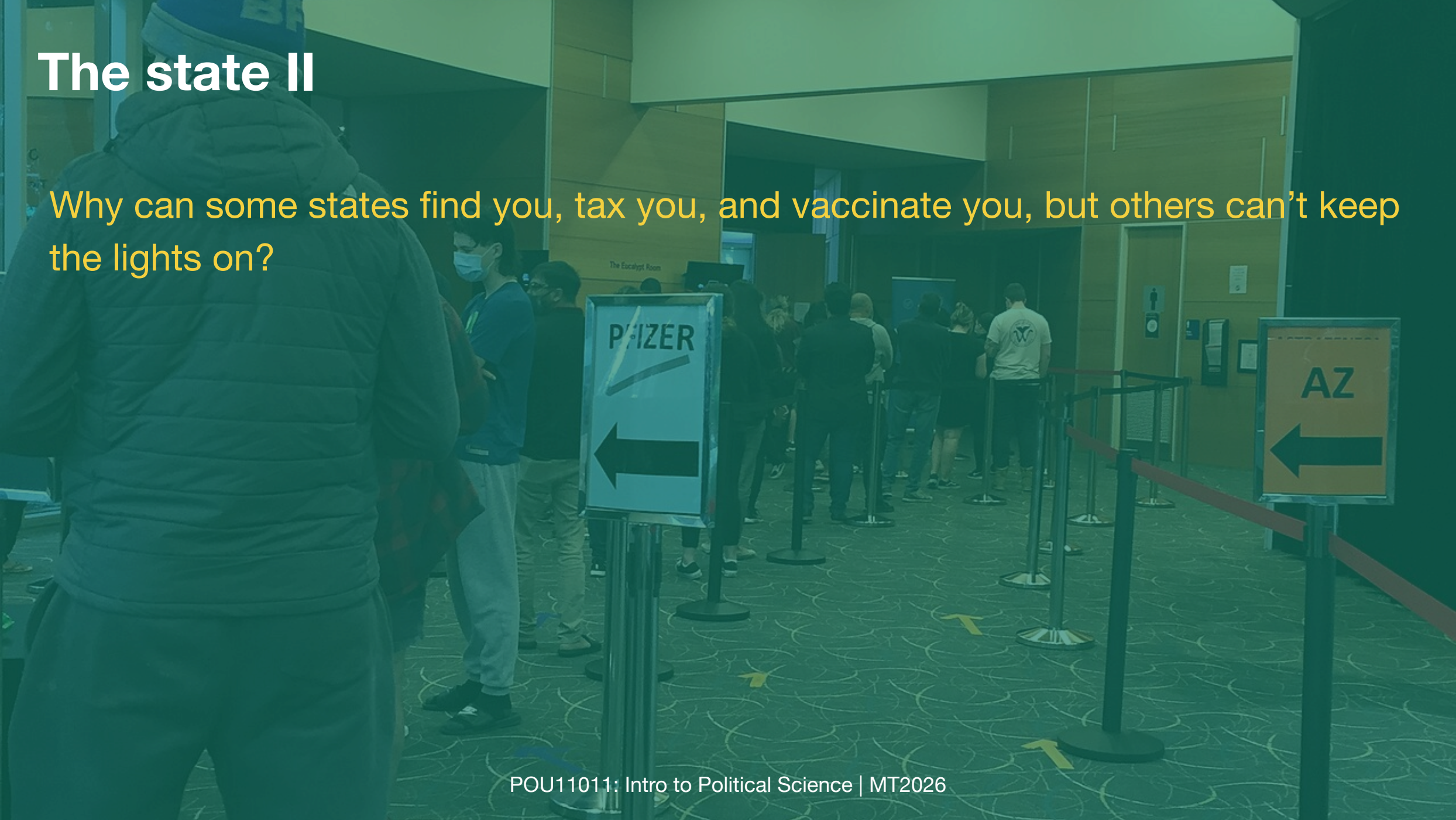
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Friday 2 October 2026

The state II

Why can some states find you, tax you, and vaccinate you, but others can't keep the lights on?



Today

- **Finishing Tuesday:** Hobbes and Locke, and state vs government vs nation
- **The puzzle:** same planet, wildly different states
- **State capacity:** what it is, how you'd measure it, and why it's not the same thing as democracy vs dictatorship
- **Building it:** can a government make its state capable on purpose?

Logistics and reminders

- To get in touch with me or your TA, please use email
- Required readings for each week are available on the syllabus (module outline) on Blackboard
 - A PDF copy of the textbook is also on Blackboard
 - Any additional book chapter readings will also be provided on Blackboard
 - Any journal articles assigned will need to be located **by you** on the **Library website** or **Google Scholar**

Logistics and reminders: tutorials and discussion points

- Everyone should attend your timetabled tutorial either next week **or** the week after
 - If you don't have a tutorial on your timetable, please email Gabriela in the political science department (polsci@tcd.ie) to have one assigned
- Submit a short Discussion Points document to Blackboard by 5pm the day before your tutorial meets
 - See the Discussion Points assignment sheet on Blackboard for more info
 - You must include the Assignment Submission Form
- If you are ever unable to attend your tutorial, such as due to illness:
 - Email your TA with an explanation, be prepared to provide documentation
 - Do this at least 24 hours before your tutorial

Confusion 1: Two questions people mix up

- **Philosophers ask: why *should* we want a state?** A justification, worked out from first principles
- **Historians and social scientists ask: how did we actually *get* states?** Tilly's answer, worked out from evidence

These two stories don't necessarily agree. The philosophy is about *legitimacy*; the history is about *war and money*.

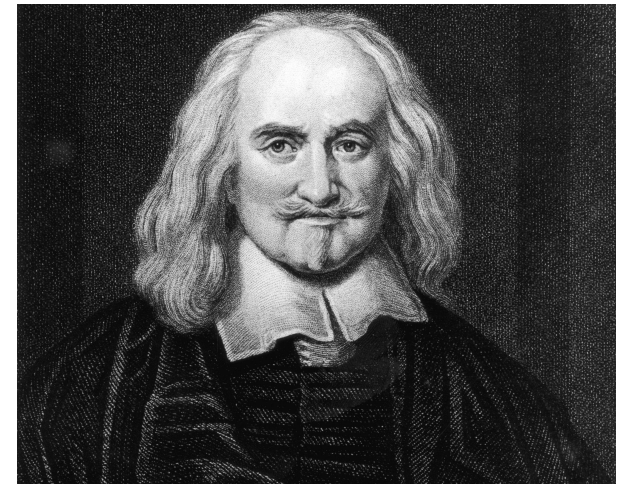
Watch for anyone, including textbooks, who slides from one to the other. (“is-ought problem”)

Hobbes: the case for an absolute state

Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (1651). What are people actually like, underneath the rules?

Without a common power to keep everyone in line, life is a war of every man against every man: “solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short.”

His fix: everyone hands *all* their rights to one absolute sovereign, the **Leviathan**, in exchange for order

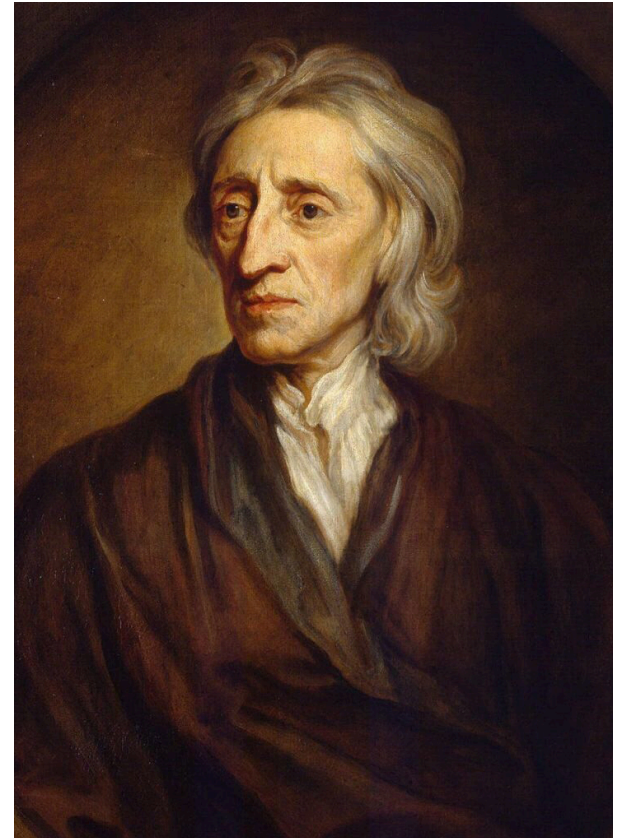


Locke: the case for a limited state

John Locke, writing decades later, starts from the same place (a state of nature, a social contract) and ends somewhere else

- People have *natural rights* (life, liberty, property) before any state exists
- The state's *only* job is to protect those rights
- Because the state can threaten those rights too, citizens need **protection against the state itself**

Hobbes gives up almost everything for order; Locke keeps a leash on the state



Are you closer to Hobbes or to Locke?

Would you hand everything to one sovereign in exchange for order, or keep a leash on the state?

One answer: we live in Locke's state.

Most constitutions list rights the state must respect, and in many countries a court can strike down a law that breaks them

Confusion 2: Three words people use a bit too interchangeably

- **State** — the permanent apparatus: courts, army, civil service, tax office. Outlasts every election
- **Government** — whoever is currently running it. Changes at elections
- **Nation** — people who *feel* they belong together. Doesn't need a state

Even more complicated when we think of “regimes”, federalism, or overlapping sovereignties

These categories and definitions are not absolute – this is the fun and interesting part of political science! (IMO)



A nation without a state, a state with several nations

- **The Kurds:** tens of millions of people with a shared language and story, split across Turkey, Iraq, Iran and Syria. Often called the largest nation without a state
- **The United Kingdom:** one state, holding England, Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland. Inside it, people who feel English, Scottish, Welsh, Irish, or British

A nation is about belonging and identity

A state is about force and territory

Same planet, wildly different states

All of them are states, and some can barely keep the lights on

Estonia vs. Lebanon



Estonia: start a business online in minutes, vote online from your laptop, get a tax return the state already pre-filled

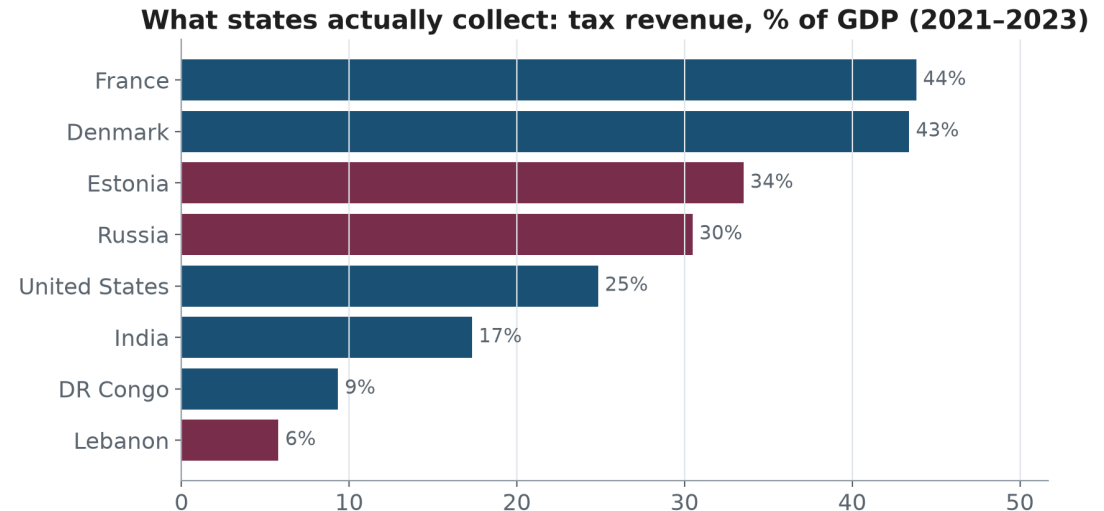
Same category of thing, “a state”, doing wildly different amounts of *actual governing*



Lebanon: the state has struggled for years to guarantee more than a few hours of electricity a day in its own capital.

The capacity gap shows up everywhere you look

- **Tax collection:** most Nordic states pull in 40%+ of GDP. Others can't reach 10–15%: not low rates, they *can't enforce collection*.
- **Vaccine rollout, 2021:** some governments texted every citizen an appointment. Others don't know how many citizens exist (!)
- **The traffic-camera test:** some states fine your car within days. Others can't deliver a letter to that address at all.



So what's actually varying?

It's not about being big, rich, or militarily powerful. Some *poor* states are highly capable; some *rich* ones surprise you with how little they can actually do.

What is the thing that's varying here?

Key term: state capacity

State capacity: *the ability of a state to actually implement its own decisions across the territory it claims to govern, to extract resources, deliver services, and enforce rules.*

Not *what the state wants to do*. What it **can** do.

Capacity isn't one number

- **Extractive:** can it raise tax reliably, from its own population?
- **Administrative:** can it run things: census, schools, roads, a bureaucracy?
- **Coercive:** can it enforce its laws and control its territory?

A state can be strong on one axis and weak on another, which is usually where the interesting cases live

What does a state with almost no capacity look like?

Haiti, 2026: at least 26 gangs control up to **90%** of the capital, Port-au-Prince UN News, March 2026

- **Coercive:** the gangs, not the police, hold most of the capital
- **Administrative and extractive:** a state that can't hold its capital can't count, tax or treat the people in it
- Nearly **1.5 million** people had fled their homes by September 2026, a record IOM

Lecture 3's Yemen, again: the monopoly has gone. Your textbook's word: a **failed state**.

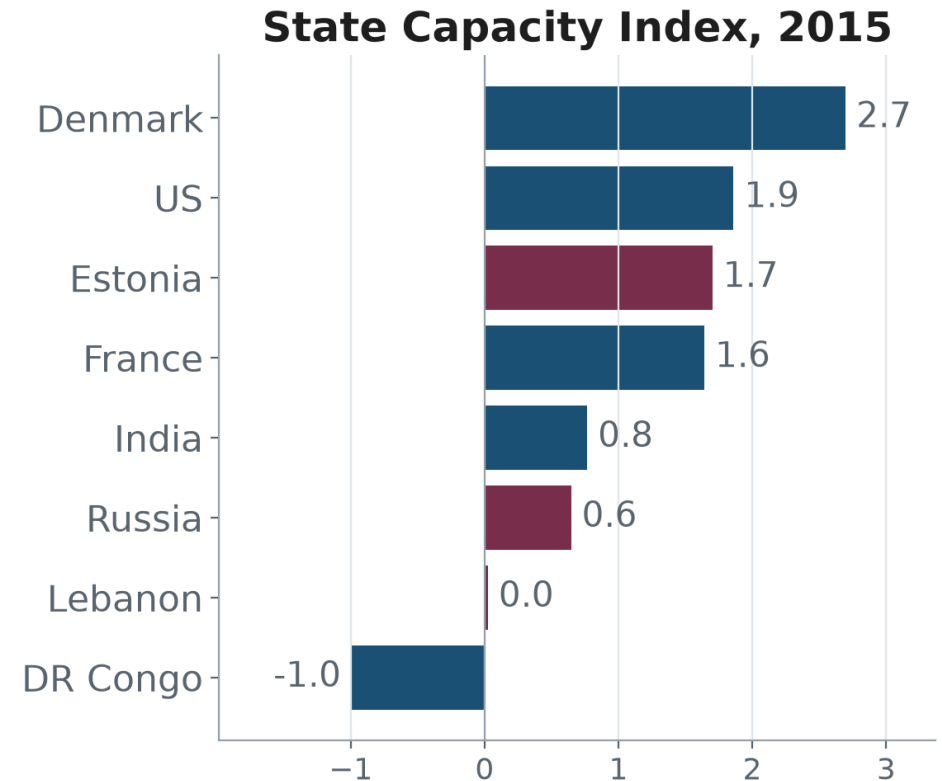


How would you *measure* this?

Same problem as Lecture 2's “how do you observe the third face of power”: capacity is mostly invisible until you go looking for a **proxy**.

- **Tax revenue as % of GDP:** the classic extractive-capacity proxy
- **Census quality:** does the state even know who and where its citizens are?
- **Mail delivery:** a test social scientists really use for basic administrative reach

Every one of these is a *proxy*, and every proxy is imperfect – be (scientifically) sceptical

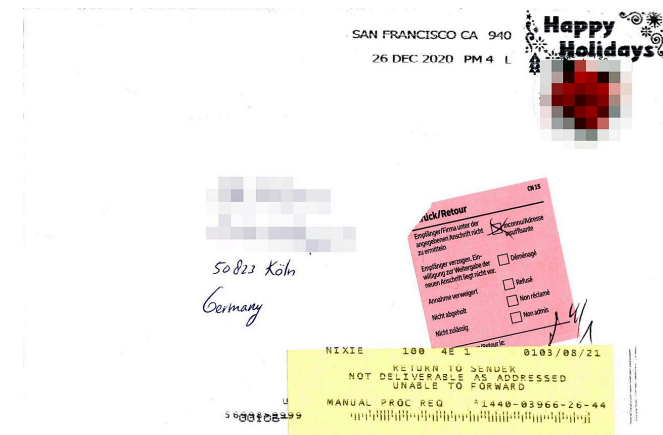


Someone actually ran the mail test!

Chong, La Porta, Lopez-de-Silanes and Shleifer (2014) sent ten letters to fake business addresses in each of **159 countries**. Would the post office send them back?

- On average, 6 in 10 came back, and only 35% within three months
- All ten came back from 21 countries, including Canada, Norway, Germany and Japan
- None came back from 16, including Cambodia and Russia

A cheap, clever proxy for administrative capacity. Still a proxy: it measures the post office, not the whole state.



Capacity ≠ regime type

Don't assume “democratic” means “capable” and “authoritarian” means “weak”

Does democracy make a state capable?

	High capacity	Low capacity
Democracy	Denmark, South Korea	many fragile new democracies
Autocracy	China, Singapore	many personalist regimes

China can build a high-speed rail network across a continent-sized country in a decade. Some *democracies* can't get a single metro line built in the same time (cough)



Can a state build capacity on purpose?

In Lecture 3, war built Europe's states and nobody planned them. Some governments set out to build one.

What does a capable bureaucracy look like?

Weber again (Lecture 3): legal-rational authority, put to work, is a **bureaucracy**, run by written, impersonal rules

- **Hired on merit:** by competitive exam, not through connections
- **Paid properly:** so the salary, not the bribe, is the income
- **Bound by rules:** the same rules for everyone who walks in

The opposite is a **spoils system**: government jobs handed out as rewards for political support
→ “**clientelism**”

Britain hired by exam from 1870. The US followed in 1883, after a rejected job-seeker shot President Garfield (!)



Georgia, 2004: fire the entire traffic police

Drivers were pulled over every few kilometres for a bribe

- **July 2004:** the whole traffic police, about 15,000 officers, fired at once, with two months' pay and an amnesty
- **August 2004:** 2,400 new patrol police, hired by exam, on ten times the old pay
- **No cash at the roadside:** fines are paid at a bank, not to the officer

Confidence in the police: **10%** in 2003, **84%** in 2010 World Bank, 2012



Where we got to today

- **State capacity** is what a state *can* do: extract, administer, coerce. It comes apart, and it is hard to measure
- Capacity is a different axis from democracy vs dictatorship
- It can be built on purpose: Georgia hired on merit, paid properly and cut out the bribes

Next up

Next lecture, Ideologies I: liberalism, conservatism, socialism

Who *should* get what, and who decides? The isms, but taught as competing answers to a real question, not a taxonomy to memorise.

Read ahead: Heywood & Laing Ch. 2 (start).

See you Tuesday

See you Tuesday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.